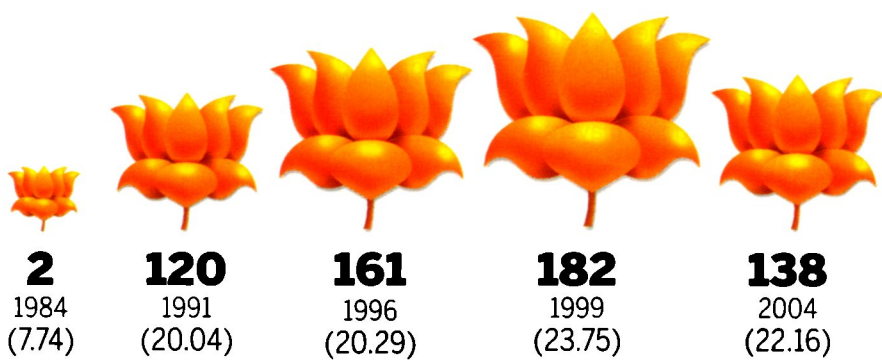


who have seen meteoric rise are learning the hard lesson: what goes up comes down

The Lotus blooms only to wilt



Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent

NO STIMULUS PACKAGE IS WORKING FOR BJP, WHICH SAW PHENOMENAL GROWTH UNTIL 2003 BUT IS NOW CAUGHT IN A MELTDOWN.

BJP

- S** The party has successfully projected Advani as its only prime ministerial candidate and matched it with a cyber campaign.
- W** Lost many old partners, yet to firm up new ones. While making itself acceptable to allies, it may lose core support base.
- O** Is banking on anti-incumbency factor. Hopes the internal security and economic situation will work in its favour.
- T** In a rapidly-changing political environment, it hopes the single largest party status will naturally attract new allies.

51

IS THE NUMBER OF SEATS THAT STATE AND REGIONAL PARTIES WON IN 1991. THE SAME PARTIES ACCOUNTED FOR 154 IN 2004.

though his party has long ceased to be the party with a difference. The attitude is commendable. At this youthful old age, an inspired Advani wants to bring a dash of Obama to his campaign. Candidate Obama was more than the machine, the method and the style. There was a message, a very powerful one. What is Advani's? A prisoner of his image managers, the legendary organisation man is getting far removed from his constituency. For Sonia, the campaign medium is the party, and that's how it has always been for the supreme leader. On the election eve, the truth is starker: the national clout of both Congress and BJP is pretty notional. And their leaders have no choice but to cede ground to the regional dictators. It is the power of the periphery versus the fallibility of the Centre.

Remember what the then Congress president Sitaram Kesri said at the 1997 AICC plenary in Kolkata? "The Congress itself is the most successful coalition". It was till Mrs G was around. It took Congress some more time to realise that it is no

more a "natural choice" for governance. The BJP was quick to learn. After its 13-day government in May 1996, the party forged an 18-party alliance for the 1998 General Elections and in 1999 it went on to prove that coalitions are a necessity. Today, only in seven states out of 28—Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Delhi—BJP and Congress fight elections head on. They account for just one-sixth of the total Lok Sabha seats. In Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, Congress is a marginal player; in Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and the north-eastern states except Assam, BJP is struggling to get a toe-hold.

In this election season, the "national" leaders are being reminded of their dispensability by the big daddies from the states. Pedigree or experience on the national stage can no longer intimidate the so-called provincials with a captive following. Last week, both BJP chief Lalu Prasad Yadav and Shiv Sena boss Bal Thackeray did exactly that. Lalu told Sonia in no uncertain terms